There are developmental frictions as well, as those more advanced seek to protect their leads. This is evident in the domains of trade, climate, patents and cross-border transactions, among others. At the heart of the contestation with the West is the tension between those who have dominated for long and others who now seek to challenge. The promotion of a rules-based order is regularly advocated, just as respect for the UN Charter is frequently invoked. But for all the talk, it is still largely Western nations that shape the agenda and define the norms. A fairer and less selective application of rules in various domains is, therefore, very much part of rebalancing. If global conversations have become more animated of late, much of it emanates from the courage to call out what is unacceptable. But for all these differences, the fact remains that those Asian nations have progressed fastest who have done so in partnership with the West.

For India, there are lessons to be learnt from how East and Southeast Asian nations leveraged geopolitics to accelerate national development. This is particularly relevant in our contemporary era of polarization. After all, no relationship is conducted without context, and the immediate one must inform India's choices even more than the distant.

In the discourses of Delhi, the term 'strategic autonomy' is usually defined as keeping a distance from the West, especially the US. The irony is that this has led us instead to develop deep dependencies elsewhere. The same logic applied in the case of non-alignment too. As we now move into a capable and confident era, it is important that our outlook is determined more by our interests and less by our insecurities.

Going by common sense, Indians must ask themselves which geographies give better access to their products and talents. As a long-term trend, there is also a fit between Western demand and Indian demographics that will help shape the global knowledge economy. Political choices, therefore, should not be divorced from those of economics, sociology or culture. There may be a process of subtle contestation between India and a world largely shaped by the West. Some of that may also show up in hedging, a phenomenon well established in the political domain. But here too, there are good reasons to be discerning and deliberate, rather than allow an attitude to become a strategy. India may be non-West but must realize that there is little profit in being anti-West.

Certainly, a calculation to broaden partners and ensure maximum benefits is an obvious one. But increasingly, in a tech-driven world, not all